

Chapter 189 - Part 1

Extra 11-1

The day Zhao Xuning and Shen Hui went to register their marriage, it rained.

The date was chosen casually.

Though calling it casual wasn't quite accurate. It was just that the night before, after Zhao Xuning finished her bath, she stood by the window overlooking the night scene below.

She and Shen Hui had moved back to where they lived during university.

Looking down from above, one could see the medical university at a glance.

The days seemed to have returned to when they first met.

But in reality, they hadn't.

Both of them knew that now was different from before.

No one took the initiative to bring up the matter of the little one. They were living their normal lives, dating, no longer making things difficult for each other.

Just that there was less intimacy between them.

Perhaps it was because time had passed, or perhaps it was the distance that came from putting a broken mirror back together.

When Shen Hui called Zhao Xuning, she no longer called her "wife" or "baby" in that soft, sweet way, but rather lazily and casually called her by name.

Really calling out her full name, surname and all.

Zhao Xuning felt disoriented several times, as if they weren't together.

But they quickly moved in together again.

In the dim yellow light, on the soft bed, Shen Hui's voice was still no different. Her fingers would still scratch heavily across Zhao Xuning's back like before, but after they finished, Shen Hui could always detach herself quickly.

Zhao Xuning couldn't help but think of the past again.

Back then, after they finished, Shen Hui would always burrow into her arms, even if their bodies were sweaty and sticky.

Zhao Xuning didn't really like this feeling. Especially at first, her cleanliness obsession and OCD made it so she had to shower after finishing, but Shen Hui would hold her back, trapping her on the bed with both legs, then rolling into her arms acting cute: "Wife, hug me~"

Her voice was extremely lazy from the exhaustion after their activities.

There were times when Zhao Xuning ignored her coquetry and got up to shower.

But when she came out after showering, all the lights in the room would be turned off, and Shen Hui would be curled up under the covers, her shoulders shaking.

When she cried, her eyes would turn red, her light brown pupils beautiful beyond words.

Always arousing Zhao Xuning's desire again.

Later on, no one knew if it was Zhao Xuning bullying Shen Hui until she cried, or if Shen Hui just liked to cry.

Back then, Zhao Xuning always said she was a crybaby.

When Shen Hui first met Zhao Xuning, Zhao Xuning didn't have the habit of carrying tissues. She was more likely to carry wet wipes.

Those single-pack wet wipes—she'd usually have two or three on her.

But later, Zhao Xuning developed the habit of carrying tissues with her.

Because Shen Hui's tear ducts were too active.

Zhao Xuning was often afraid of making her cry, yet also liked making her cry.

But back then, they seemed very intimate. Intimate enough to eat from the same plate, sleep under the same blanket, embrace each other on hot summer days, share the same takoyaki¹ in winter, and walk hand in hand at night markets.

But now the distance was close, yet also far.

Breaking the ice required just one sentence.

But making all the ice melt and blend with the originally calm water seemed very difficult.

Zhao Xuning didn't know what to do.

So after finishing her shower, she stood by the window and saw not far away a red neon sign, connected to form their school's name.

Inexplicably, she suddenly thought of marriage.

If they got married, would things be different?

Zhao Xuning thought, probably they would be.

If the relationship couldn't break through the ice, then they'd take it a step further.

When Shen Hui came out after showering, Zhao Xuning's hair was already almost dry. She still took out the hairdryer, having Shen Hui lean against the sofa, basically falling into her arms, gently and slowly blow-drying Shen Hui's hair.

Zhao Xuning's movements were very light.

The moment the hairdryer sound stopped, Zhao Xuning suddenly said: "Ah Hui, let's get married."

Shen Hui had been playing with a rubber band in her hands. Hearing her say this, the taut rubber band suddenly snapped.

The particularly loud sound made the space feel oppressive.

The rubber band happened to snap against Shen Hui's finger, immediately leaving a red mark.

It hurt so much she drew in a sharp breath.

Zhao Xuning immediately picked up her finger, frowning. After looking, it really wasn't a serious wound, but the instant a rubber band snaps against a finger, the pain truly strikes at the heart.

But Shen Hui wasn't paying attention to this.

She was more concerned with Zhao Xuning's words, but when the words reached her lips, she didn't know how to ask.

Zhao Xuning lowered her head, seriously rubbing her finger, trying to disperse that red mark, but the red mark kept expanding.

Zhao Xuning suddenly gently took her finger into her mouth.

Shen Hui could just see the top of her head, and Zhao Xuning's falling hair strands also happened to land on the back of Shen Hui's hand.

Even her hair carried warmth.

Shen Hui responded softly: "Mm."

Zhao Xuning's spine stiffened.

Shen Hui pulled her finger out and patted her back lightly, "Go get some alcohol."

Zhao Xuning: "?"

Although she didn't know what Shen Hui wanted to do, Zhao Xuning obediently did it.

She poured the alcohol for Shen Hui, then sat beside her, at a loss.

After a few glasses of alcohol, Shen Hui finally asked: "Zhao Xuning, do you still like me?"

Zhao Xuning had also drunk a few glasses, drinking hastily. After finishing, her face slightly flushed, she leaned close to Shen Hui and when she wasn't paying attention, secretly kissed her, then sat up straight all proper and serious, "I like you."

Shen Hui asked again: "Why do you want to marry me?"

Zhao Xuning: "..."

This question stumped Zhao Xuning. But after thinking about it, she finally sighed and said: "Ah Hui."

Zhao Xuning hugged her waist. The way she called her was intricate and winding, tender and gentle, "I want to be properly together with you."

Not the kind where they tortured each other.

The kind where they loved each other and could embrace each other.

She thought the three thousand steps were the end.

But later discovered that was merely the fuse to start over.

Now the fuse was still burning, and this fuse seemed to have no end.

Both of them were damp; no matter how the fuse crackled, it wouldn't ignite.

Zhao Xuning said: "Shen Hui, I want to love you properly."

Shen Hui asked her: "What counts as loving properly?"

Zhao Xuning thought for two seconds: "Mm... I don't know how to say it."

Shen Hui stared at her, then after a moment smiled, "Fool."

Both reproachful and shy.

But later, after drinking too much, Shen Hui and Zhao Xuning kissed during their eye contact. Shen Hui asked hazily: "Will it be sunny tomorrow?"

Zhao Xuning nodded: "Mm."

"Then let's get married."

And so, on a day that wasn't particularly special, the two decided on marriage.

But they didn't expect it would be a rainy day.

Footnotes:

¹ Takoyaki (章魚小丸子) - A Japanese snack/street food consisting of balls of batter filled with octopus, also known as octopus balls

Chapter 189 - Part 2

Extra 11-2

The heavy rain cast a layer of mist over the city, and the windshield wipers continuously swept across the glass.

Zhao Xuning was driving, Shen Hui sat in the passenger seat playing with her phone.

The procedures for registering their marriage were complicated, but both were extremely patient.

Just a bit polite with each other.

Especially Zhao Xuning, who carefully tended to Shen Hui's emotions, afraid of taking a wrong step.

Shen Hui was somewhat better.

The two took photos for their marriage certificate, then received the stamped marriage certificates. They looked very calm, unlike the other couples who had their arms linked or waists embraced, or fingers intertwined while talking and laughing.

Once in the car, Zhao Xuning stared at the marriage certificate, looking at it over and over.

Shen Hui asked her: "What's so interesting about it?"

Zhao Xuning smiled slightly, "It just looks good."

Shen Hui said nothing more.

Despite having registered their marriage, these days still left Zhao Xuning feeling insecure.

This state continued until the second month after their marriage.

That day, Zhao Xuning went to pick up Shen Hui from work. Because it was their one-year anniversary of registering, Zhao Xuning had reserved a restaurant, planning to have a date with Shen Hui that evening.

But she didn't expect that when picking up Shen Hui, she'd see her walking together with a young girl.

The girl was youthful and energetic, wearing a pretty school uniform, her face full of collagen. When she spoke, her ponytail swayed back and forth, looking so comfortable.

Shen Hui stood beside her, but no matter how Zhao Xuning looked at it, she found it grating.

Zhao Xuning sat in the car for a long time, not daring to get out.

Because Shen Hui was chatting with someone, she was afraid that if she appeared, she'd spoil Shen Hui's mood.

She also knew that Shen Hui definitely wasn't the type to cheat.

Zhao Xuning also looked down on Gu Chunmian.

But that day, she just felt indescribably dejected.

The girl's eyes revealed a desire to conquer that couldn't be faked.

As an Alpha, Zhao Xuning could naturally see that kind of look.

Shen Hui probably hadn't noticed yet that this girl was very interested in her.

So the two were chatting quite happily.

Zhao Xuning subconsciously checked herself in the mirror.

Her face was far from the girl's youthfulness. After all, age was there. Although she was good-looking, she couldn't escape time.

Now when she smiled, there were already fine lines at the corners of her eyes, just not very obvious.

But when the little girl smiled, she only had pretty dimples.

Then, when the girl used the excuse that Shen Hui had something on her face and suddenly leaned close to Shen Hui's face, reaching out to wipe her face.

Shen Hui was first startled and took half a step back. Who knew the girl would say with a grin: "Sister, you had something on your face."

Only then did Shen Hui realize she'd overreacted.

Zhao Xuning sat in the car, her anger already reaching its critical point.

She deliberately opened the car window a bit, enough to let sound come in.

So she heard the girl say with a smile: "Sister, don't you want to know what was on your face?"

Shen Hui: "What?"

The girl: "A bit of cuteness."

Shen Hui: "..."

"No." The girl changed her words again, "More than just a bit of cuteness."

Unable to bear it any longer.

Zhao Xuning opened the car door and walked in front of Shen Hui, then pulled Shen Hui behind herself.

The girl was startled, "Who are you, elder sister?"

"Her wife." Zhao Xuning said: "She's married, show some self-respect."

The girl looked at Shen Hui, but Zhao Xuning pulled Shen Hui away, fuming with anger.

This was the first time Zhao Xuning had gotten angry in front of Shen Hui since they got back together. Before, she was always being so careful.

Zhao Xuning put Shen Hui in the passenger seat, then got in the car, fastened her seatbelt, turned the car around directly, pressed the gas pedal to the floor, and drove away in a cloud of dust.

The girl stood there dumbfounded.

Shen Hui also sat in the car dumbfounded.

Zhao Xuning's expression was too terrible, yet also very easy to read.

After all, Shen Hui had been with her for many years.

She'd seen this expression on her face many times.

It was jealousy.

Whenever Shen Hui got a bit closer to other people, Zhao Xuning would show this expression, just never this obviously.

Before, she would always keep it bottled up sullenly, waiting for Shen Hui to notice and coax her.

Zhao Xuning drove Shen Hui straight home.

Shen Hui changed her shoes unhurriedly, saying nothing.

Zhao Xuning sat on the sofa sulking, angry to death.

"Shen Hui." Zhao Xuning called her.

Shen Hui responded lowly but didn't acknowledge her, much less coax her like before.

After a long while, Zhao Xuning finally uttered: "I feel awful."

Shen Hui asked: "What's wrong?"

Shen Hui stood right in front of Zhao Xuning. Zhao Xuning looked up, her eyes red.

Shen Hui had already softened but still pretended indifference, "You have to tell me."

"I'm jealous." Zhao Xuning said.

Shen Hui nodded: "And then?"

Zhao Xuning got anxious, suddenly standing up. She was immediately taller, and said in exasperation: "Coax me."

Zhao Xuning hugged her, pinching her waist, "You always coaxed me before."

Shen Hui buried her face in her shoulder and laughed softly.

The Zhao Xuning from before was growing, and also coming back.

The past wouldn't be dwelled upon, the future was still coming.